The Great Trickster

Contents

[English text unavailable] 2
Red 3
Blue 7
Green 11
Purple 15
Aqua 18
Yellow 21
White 25

[English text unavailable]

COL-311100

Noire: The art of storytelling in film began the moment directors realized the audience could weave meaning between scenes.

Noire: Thus came in the technique of Montage.

Noire's Mansion

Delicate blue light sculpts the edge of Noire's cheekbone, and in her eyes the reflection of a glowing screen.

Noire: Once sound was only a dream, then a distant companion, onward until sound and image became inseparable, and now, we live in the era of digital editing.

The screen's flashes reflect in Noire's eyes.

Noire: What will come next? Movies projected straight from my mind to the audience, or visuals seamlessly streamed into theirs?

Beneath the rapid flicker of the convex screen lies a colorful composition, formed by thousands of units distorted faintly along the curved glass.

Noire slides the cursor with precision, placing a clip neatly onto the editing timeline.

Noire: The tools get slicker, but the core of a story? It's the same old song we've always sung.

Noire: Trim, select, position, merge ...

Noire: Try as we might to disguise it. Stories are just lies with good marketing.

Beneath a crescendo of keystrokes and mouse movements, Noire's pointer shifts her video segments from one track to another.

On the screen, the man's tear-streaked face hangs in the delicate balance between despair over death and elation for rebirth.

A single crisp noise, and then all is dark.

Noire: Hmm?

There is nothing in the silence, nothing but the dark.

The fan keeps spinning for a moment longer, dwindling to a stop under its own inertia.

Noire: A blackout?

The neighborhood outside is a curtain of darkness. At least, that confirmation saves her the trouble of another breaker-box routine.

Noire: Damn it. The footage I just cut ... Don't tell me it's all lost. There's no way this software doesn't autosave, right?

Noire: So this is the curse of new tech, huh? Cutting-edge, but unreliable when it really matters. I guess every solution starts off as a band-aid for disaster.

Noire: Thank God it was just some test footage. If it were an actual film ...

Noire drums her fingertips on the rim of her wheel, the sharp clicks and soft reverberations grounding her—a reminder not to linger too long in hypotheticals.

Noire: If this were an actual film, I'd be hitting save every few minutes just to keep sane.

After composing herself, Noire tilts to one side, her voice calm and low as she speaks to the wheelchair.

Noire: Let's roll on over to Noire's Set.

Two puppets on either side of her wheels move deftly in response, ushering Noire to her studio —"Noire's Set," as she calls it.

Red

COL-311101

Red

click

Even in the pitch dark, Noire manages her way into the studio with ease.

Film Studio

Noire: Aa Zing, fire up the spare generator. Aa Ziu, Aa Dou, get the lights.

The trio of puppets scurry out from the wheelchair, their small, animated figures fussing noisily before the miniature generator starts whirring.

Aa Ziu: Ka!

Shadows shift as her puppets flit through the darkness. With the generator now humming, one of them hurries toward the spotlight.

Aa Ziu: Ka, ka!

The puppet fumbles in the darkness, misaligning its aim. The spotlight beams into Noire's eyes, still fragile from the lack of light.

Noire: Tsk.

Reacting on impulse, Noire raises her hand against the light. Her displeasure saturates the puppets' wooden minds like an unspoken command.

Aa Ziu: Ka!

In its rush to fix the spotlight, the puppet Aa Ziu trips over the complex mesh of wires in the shadows, setting off a cascade of entanglements.

Aa Ziu: Ka, ka, ka, ka!

Like a row of dominoes collapsing in the dark, the chaos builds with each moment careening into disaster.

Aa Dou: Ka ...

The other puppets freeze on the spot, their wooden limbs stiff with hesitation, while Aa Ziu, overwhelmed, twists and writhes on the floor, its nonexistent wooden spine bending in imagined distress.

Noire has twisted away from the lamp as she slowly allows her eyes to adjust to the red twilight.

Noire: Oh!

Surrounded by vivid red, Noire's gaze locks onto the clear divide between her dark silhouette and the glowing wall.

Noire: Red is blood and passion.

Noire: It's also the fading light of dusk, the fires of damnation, and the tenderest warmth.

She lets her mind now alight with ideas, flowing seamlessly into the fiery crimson hue.

Aa Ziu: Ka-ta ...?

The confusion clouding Aa Ziu's mind fades as it figures out how to move its own body.

It seems unsure how or even whether it should rectify its misstep.

Noire: Stop.

Aa Ziu's extended hand is suspended in the air, and the red light's edge swells around her shadow.

Noire: Flames, fire—the genesis of civilization.

Noire: Creation and destruction, an endless cycle, eternal and unstoppable ...

Noire lets her mind wander, drinking in the vivid, singular hue.

Aa Ziu: Ka!

Catching the ripples of her delight, Aa Ziu folds over and lies flat on the floor.

Noire: Flames ... my desire, swelling and rising, devouring with every breath.

She traces the curves of her hand, imagining a tiny fire resting within her palm.

Noire: This fire is what has kept me burning.

Red 1980

Qi Xing: Well, I'll be damned. You've actually got a professional setup going on here.

He Rijun and Qi Xing enter behind Noire. The stale air of the room is punctuated by the soft "clack" of Qi Xing's lollipop tapping her teeth.

The sound feels heavy, as if dropping to the floor before it can travel any further.

Qi Xing: Square boxes, boxes with lights, boxes with buttons—what's the deal with all this stuff?

Qi Xing's eyes sweep across the room, finding little to be impressed with.

Her hand comes to hover over some machinery. She gives it a curious tap before her fingers inch toward the inviting buttons.

Noire: This "stuff" costs more than most people make in a lifetime.

Qi Xing scoffs, hovering her fingers over the tempting buttons.

He Rijun: It's probably best if you don't touch anything, and, um, it might be a good idea to put on some slippers while you're in here.

She tugs on Qi Xing's clothing, tilting her head up so that it nearly rests on her shoulder.

Being shorter, if just barely, she always finds herself tilting her head up toward her.

She avoids meeting Qi Xing's eyes.

Noire: Slippers are by the door. They're disinfected. Grab any pair that fits.

Qi Xing scans her eyes over to a cabinet filled with identical white slippers.

He Rijun, accustomed to the routine, trades her boots for slippers and sets her footwear by the door.

Qi Xing: You must get a lot of traffic in here to have all of those things.

He Rijun: There always seems to be someone that needs to go over things here.

Noire strides over to the printer, looking back with a half smile.

Noire: Let me guess, you forgot the script we gave you, right? We're going to need it.

Noire: Don't worry. I'll print out another copy. Teresa, would you go through the notes I jotted down earlier?

He Rijun: Of course.

Qi Xing casts a sharp look at Noire before following Teresa to the slipper rack, giving no thought to the size.

Qi Xing: So, you said you make movies. Anything I would have seen?

Noire: Do any of those posters look familiar to you?

Noire's reply drips with condescension. Their tension feels like a rubber band about to snap.

With every intention of ignoring the posters, she leans over the devices near her, trying to decipher their English labels.

She scans them methodically, before arriving at a particular oddity.

Qi Xing: Is this a handheld camera? How old is this thing?

She takes the bulky handheld camera and turns it over in her hands, scrutinizing it from all angles.

Noire: That's the first camera I ever owned. It's been with me for more than a decade. I've never had the heart to let it go.

Qi Xing: A decade ...

Qi Xing looks up with unconcealed astonishment. Cameras like this have only just started showing up in the local markets.

Noire: It's a Super 8 camera. I think I was 16 when I got it.

Qi Xing: You've been shooting movies since you were a kid?

Noire nods.

He Rijun: That's around the same age I started writing scripts, about 15 or 16?

Qi Xing: You two go that far back then?

She places the camera down delicately, as if it were a priceless antique.

He Rijun: Actually, we met at university. We were in the same class.

Qi Xing: Oh ...

Qi Xing returns to the camera before shifting back to the duo as they set out their papers.

Qi Xing: And I would have just been another girl pouring drinks at a street corner icehouse. Making movies was never even on my radar.

Qi Xing: Until I happened to be there to scare off some creep trying to hit on a girl. Now you two weirdos are telling me I'm lead actress material.

She eyes them from head to toe and back again, trying her best to conceal her real thoughts.

She bridges the lingering silence again.

Qi Xing: See ...

She suddenly feels the urge to withdraw into the silence, but that's never been her way.

Qi Xing: Less than an hour ago, I stepped into a high-end car, stepped out into a mansion, ditched my busted-up sneakers at the door, and walked into someone else's life.

Qi Xing: I always figured life-changing moments came at you with a bang, like an egg exploding in a microwave—something you could pinpoint down to the second.

Qi Xing: But it's funny. Once you're finally in your stride, you forget exactly where it all began.

Qi Xing: All I know is I feel like this is a whole new stage for my life.

Qi Xing removes the lollipop from her mouth.

Keeping her composure, she turns back around, determined not to show her growing sense of envy.

Qi Xing: So, uh, how did all this start out?

He Rijun: Start out? You mean, when did we start working together?

He Rijun glances quickly at Noire's turned back.

Qi Xing: Not that, I mean just ... finding your passion and sticking with it.

She had loved painting once, then playing the harmonica, but her passion for them always dwindled away.

The struggle for survival and sustenance grew like an overinflated balloon, leaving no room for anything else in her mind.

Steering clear of her father's former cellmates, covering rent for the month, staying alive, figuring out how to spend even less just to get by—endlessly innovating new ways to make it to the next day.

She had fought every day against life, against hunger, and strict reform school teachers, while these two indulged in their hobbies, basking in the gentle warmth of privilege.

Qi Xing: Is this what the world looks like behind the spotless marble walls?

He Rijun: Hmm. I just wanted to write, so I did, and I kept at it.

Qi Xing waits, but Teresa seems to have flustered over what to say.

She works better with a pen in hand, crossing out and rewriting words until her ideas take shape.

Noire: It started as a simple slip of the tongue.

Noire, still standing at the printer, picks up the dropped conversation.

Noire: I remember my mother reading me a bedtime story. She told me that the princess shouldn't have taken a bite of that apple.

Noire: But I couldn't help thinking—how would that even make any sense? Then the princess would be stuck in that cottage with those weird bearded guys forever. The story would lose all its appeal.

Noire: And then I asked myself, what if she didn't eat the apple, then what would happen next? I imagined her finding a bear, one followed by a hunter, or perhaps saving a villager that she'd fall in love with.

The printer drones on as Noire gathers a portion of the script and turns to face Qi Xing.

Noire: That's when I decided I'd create my own stories.

Qi Xing: Sounds like you should've been a screenwriter like Little Jun here.

Hearing someone over ten years her junior call her "Little Jun," Teresa feels compelled to say something but ultimately bites back her words.

Noire: Words weren't enough for me.

Noire: Flipping through that fairytale, I came to a conclusion: Pictures could carry my story farther than words ever could.

Noire: But even that wasn't enough. I wanted to be taken seriously.

Noire: And what was taken seriously? Movies, television—mediums that captivate the masses.

Noire: Each moving image adds layers of story, then the music, each part amplifying the narrative.

Noire: That's why I picked up a camera, because I wanted to tell my story through its lens. But even now, it still isn't enough.

Qi Xing: It isn't enough.

Noire flips on the television. The screen depicts a reel of film burning.

Qi Xing: I've seen this before.

Qi Xing's memories recede back to a moment in time, ducking into the dark of the movie theater to escape her father's rougher "acquaintances."

Qi Xing: I knew from the first time I saw it that this was more than just a movie for this guy. He was always chasing something bigger, chasing the light, chasing the shadows. His camera was pointed right at the rising sun, just as dawn broke.

Qi Xing: He wanted that shot so bad that he'd let the sun cook his eyes and burn his film. He got his dawn, then it got him.

Qi Xing: Still, you've got to hand it to the guy.

Noire: So, you are familiar with my work, after all.

Noire says as if confirming the obvious.

Noire: It was my first hit, the one that really made a name for me in the industry. The film's last frame was a pure block of red. That's all it took for people to box me into a style.

Noire: You could say that red gave me everything, but then it took it all away.

Blue

COL-311102

Blue

???: Ms. Noire?

???: Vitals are stabilizing. We should begin immediate ...

???: I'm sorry, but the patient is still unconscious. She can't answer your questions right now.

Blue 1982

Ward

The instant Noire opens her eyes, agony ripples through her body, fracturing into a haze of static that clears to reveal a sterile blue hospital.

But her own suffering is not what first comes to mind.

Noire: What's the progress on the film?

Her assistant springs to attention the moment she hears Noire's voice, like a puppet pulled up on a string.

Lin: Y-you're awake.

Her last recollection is vivid—the glare of harsh light, a feeling of weightlessness, the crushing impact, and the sound of shattering glass—pain and panic creeping in.

Noire: What's the progress on the film?

The flow of her breath carries the words out of her mouth weakly. Still muddied by her scattered, dreamlike stupor. The urgency of it overcoming all obstacles.

Lin: The film is on hold for now. Everyone was too exhausted to go on, so I suggested they go home and rest.

Noire: *sigh*

Lin: The writing team's still brainstorming the big climax. They need more time to get it down.

It was precisely the climactic moments of her latest film, Shadow Spy, that were failing to meet both her investors' and her own expectations. The crew had been running on overdrive for months, striving to produce a cut that could satisfy both parties.

Lin: Your first priority should be resting up.

Noire: I need to get home.

Her studio there was more than just a workspace for Noire. It was where her thoughts came into alignment, where so many scripts had been given life.

Lin: Considering your current state, I think staying here will be the wisest choice.

Not one to repeat herself, Noire tries to sit up, but her body doesn't move with her.

Pain. It shoots through her spine, burrowing into her brain. It spreads to her arms, as if biting through the marrow of her bones, until it stops.

Noire: ...

A flash of pity passes across her assistant's face.

Noire: Hmm?

Her legs don't hurt at all.

They're still there, limply splayed out under her hospital gown, yet Noire cannot spur them to move.

Noire: ...?

Lin is sitting at the edge of her bed. She seems to wordlessly offer a thousand apologies, but it isn't her fault.

Lin: You don't remember, do you? The car accident after leaving the set? You suffered severe nerve damage.

Lin quickly follows up with another statement, trying to soften the blow.

Lin: But the doctors think there might be a chance you can recover.

Noire: Did they find the whoever did this to me?

She falls back into the bed, allowing her head to sink fully into the hospital pillow.

Lin: The police came by while you were out. The doctor said they'd notify them when you woke up.

Noire: How long do I need to be here?

Lin: They said you'll have to go through some rehabilitation. I don't know how long. The doctor wanted to wait until you were awake.

Noire lifts her chin, attempting a nod.

Noire: What about the script? It was in the car with me.

Lin: What's left of your car will be in the impound lot. Everything inside it is probably going to be evidence.

Lin: But, I printed a fresh copy for you! Let me know if it looks okay. I've also attached some new outlines from the writers for you to think over.

Noire: Thank you.

She takes the script and presses the button on her morphine injector before leafing through the pages.

Noire: I'd like to be alone now.

Lin holds a look at her employer for a brief moment.

Lin: Alright. Get some rest.

Hallway, Hospital

Lin: *panting*

Once the door is shut, Lin leans against the hallway corridor, breathing as if she had just avoided her own near-death experience.

Before she can compose herself, she notices that her colleagues have arranged themselves nearby.

Photographer: So, Her Highness has finally awakened?

Lin: Yeah.

Alisa: How did she take the news?

Lin: She seems ... calm.

Photographer: Of course, she'd never let herself break down in front of you. Meanwhile, we're one all-nighter away from a meltdown!

Alisa: After all that she's put us through, doesn't it kind of make you believe in karma?

Photographer: What do you think? Was it someone on the crew behind the wheel of that other car? Place your bets.

Lin: It doesn't matter how it happened. At least, we'll finally get a little break.

Alisa: Maybe not so little. Do you think the film can survive this?

As the realization jumps from person to person, all eyes turn to Lin.

Alisa: Lin, you know that company we asked you to look into. Have you heard anything back from them?

Lin: Yeah, but the pay definitely won't be higher than what we're getting now. Can you handle that?

Photographer: Honestly, I think we're trading years off our lives for this paycheck!

Alisa: I'm not sure. As much hell as this job can be, at least it pays the bills.

Each coworker vents their own particular grievances, fading out from the griping. Lin steals a glance through the narrow hospital window.

Noire has propped herself up against her pillow, absentmindedly biting down on an empty ballpoint pen while sketching storyboards onto the script using the exposed ink cartridge.

She hasn't even bothered to pull the blanket over her legs.

Lin: Alright.

The guilt creeps in, no matter how bad things could get, complaining about someone at a time like this ...

Lin: Everyone should head home and get some rest.

Alisa: Sticking around for our diva, huh? I don't envy you, Lin.

Photographer: Alright, we'll be off then.

Lin: Bye.

Their farewell is light and casual. Their voices distort as they disappear down the busy hallway.

Noire: The door's not soundproof.

Noire: They're just employees to me. I don't care what they say or think, so long as they follow my directions.

Noire: And they don't impede my vision.

Noire: But I can't let this reach a point where it interferes with my work.

Lin: Ms. Noire, the nurse just came by with some news.

Noire: Oh ...

Having dealt with some paperwork, Lin returns to the ward to find Noire sitting up in bed with a vacant expression.

Her legs are dangling off the side of the bed, and her gown is damply sticking to her legs.

Lin: What happened?

Lin rushes over.

Noire: I could use some more water.

She notices a thermos on the ground by the bed, steam rising from the open top.

Lin: Hot water?

She hurriedly frees up her hands to grab the thermos, only to realize that Noire's feet are dripping scalding water onto the floor.

The heat has turned the skin on her feet bright red.

Yet her face is blank and emotionless.

Lin: Does it hurt?

She knows the answer, but looking at the burns running down her leg, she can't help but feel the pain for her.

Noire: I didn't feel a thing.

It was as if the burned skin had nothing to do with her at all.

Lin hesitates, her hand slackening, and Noire's legs slide roughly back into the bed.

Lin: Oh, sorry.

Noire: What is it?

Lin: Sorry. My hand slipped.

Noire: That's not what I'm asking about.

Noire looks at Lin like she would a reel of film.

Noire: Did you have something to do with the crash?

Lin: No.

Noire: Then why do you have so much guilt in your eyes?

Lin: B-Because ...

Lin opens her mouth, but the words catch in her throat, and she avoids answering the question.

Lin: I apologize. I didn't mean anything by it.

This is how it's always been. Once she promises to change, Noire stops challenging her.

Noire: I'm not reprimanding you. I just want to know—why do you keep looking at me like that?

There's no anger in her voice at all. Even now, with her legs burned, and the water on the floor silently spreading beneath the bed.

Lin: Because ... I ...

Lin can't bring herself to look her in the eye, but she knows Noire will not give up without an answer.

Lin: I sympathize with you.

Noire: Ah, sympathy ...

The word hangs over her head, like a thought just out of reach.

Lin: Sorry.

Noire: No need to apologize. Sympathy ... I guess I was right after all.

Noire picks up the script and writes the word on the final blank page.

Noire: Sympathy

She says it again, scoffing this time.

Noire: Perhaps that's why the perfect climax has always eluded me.

Her pen draws rings around the word.

Noire: It's a natural emotion. Teresa, I'm sure, would've appreciated it, accepted it for what it is. But I won't.

Noire: But I'm filming a movie—something for the masses. I need that kind of resonance for the masses.

Noire: It has nothing to do with you.

She looks up at Lin.

Noire: No need to sympathize with me. This accident, it's no big deal, because it won't stop me from making my films.

Noire: I won't see this as some kind of setback, as long as it doesn't get in the way of filming.

The conviction in her words begins to turn Lin's sympathy into something else. Lin is almost ashamed to have felt sorry for her.

Lin: Okay.

She nods. It isn't her place to set her limits. Not now.

Noire: So, what were you saying?

Lin: Oh!

Lin looks down at her now-empty hands and begins searching the room, spotting the accident report resting half-soaked by the dissipating patches of water.

It must have slid off the table and onto the floor during the commotion.

The words have already blurred on the waterlogged pages as Lin yanks it from the floor.

Lin: It's your accident report. I thought you might want to read it.

Noire takes the damp stack, flipping straight to the conclusion.

Noire: I ran a red light, did I ...?

Noire's brow tightens.

Noire: No, it was green lights all the way. I'm sure of that.

She turns to the window, catching sunlight reflecting from the trees.

Green

COL-311103

Green

Cemetery

A bundle of white paper is tossed into the brazier.

Noire: This isn't a bad spot.

She lounges in her wheelchair, watching the distant lake with a narrowed gaze.

The setting sun's light is refracted into countless golden streaks over its waves.

Noire: Looks like I'm late, Jun. It took longer than I expected to get from my wheelchair to the driver's seat.

Green 1982

Qi Xing: Looks like it took you a few months.

The voice drips with unveiled disgust. Noire closes her eyes in resignation.

Qi Xing: You don't seem so worse for wear.

Noire: ...

With Teresa gone, their mutual dislike had festered into something truly unpleasant.

Qi Xing walks between Noire and He Rijun's grave, placing the flowers carefully on her tombstone.

Noire: I'm not sure why I'm surprised you'd find a way to hate me after all this time.

Qi Xing looks back in anger, her eyes like arrows aimed at Noire.

Qi Xing: Surprised, really? Why would you be surprised? Didn't you get an inkling of it at her funeral? Oh, right, you weren't there.

Noire freezes up, an immovable object to Qi Xing's unrelenting force.

It would be wiser for them both if there was a change of topic.

Noire: You're the one who has been bringing these flowers.

Qi Xing: Yeah, what's it to you? You're never here. You don't deserve to be here.

Noire: And what about you?

She puts her on the back foot with that reply.

Qi Xing: I want to set things right. I messed up the ending of C07, and now I gotta live with it.

Qi Xing lowers herself until her head finds a crooked rest on the gravestone.

Qi Xing: Reunion of the Three Swallows. I should've told her sooner. I actually liked it.

Qi Xing: Now it's too late. Too damn late.

Noire guides her puppets to push the wheelchair forward, her hand patting softly on Qi Xing's shoulder.

Noire: It's not your fault. We already shielded her from so much of this. If Teresa had to face the expectations for C07 too. It would have only been worse for her.

Noire: I'm sure you have some idea about how far-fetched our investors can be with their profit margins.

The banal words find a deep purchase in her. Qi Xing clenches the grave until her knuckles are white.

Qi Xing: So is that the cost, then? Her life?!

Qi Xing at last realizes whose hand is on her shoulder.

She shoves the hand aside, standing up to distance herself from Noire.

Qi Xing: She wasn't meant to have an ending like this! Not her, and not C07!

Qi Xing: Do you think C07 would just bow out and walk away? Ever? Nah, that's just your own fairytale!

Her gaze falls to the photo stuck on the black gravestone, her fingers unconsciously tracing it.

Qi Xing: Jun opened my eyes to a whole new way of life. Without her, I'd just be another rat scurrying the alleyways of this godforsaken city.

Qi Xing: She didn't do one damn thing wrong. It was you and this company.

Qi Xing: I'm done with New Art!

Qi Xing turns and walks away, uninterested in Noire's response.

She moves swiftly along the narrow trail between the tombstones.

Noire: *sigh*

The weight of her thoughts drags her head down.

Noire: I should've come sooner.

Street, Hong Kong

Two months prior, near the set of Shadow Spy.

Noire: Tsk.

A sudden recollection makes Noire slam her fist into the steering wheel.

Noire: It's always "market viability" with them, isn't it? This is supposed to be the C07's most intense outburst in the film!

Noire: Emotions, it's always emotions.

Noire pulls off to the shoulder of the road. The busy street pulses with the sound of speeding cars behind her.

It's just a matter of time until a motorcycle patrol will pass by to slap her with a ticket.

Her nerves are fried from lack of sleep. She's been working herself to exhaustion, trying to fix the troubles plaguing Shadow Spy.

Noire: Where do I go from here, Teresa?

Noire: ...

Noire: Teresa ...

The moment she speaks her name, her death is that much more tangible, more real.

She was in the middle of a planning session when the news came in. She didn't stop then, she didn't let it hit her. She kept trying to outrun her grief.

But it hit her all the same.

While revising her protagonist's key scenes with the crew, Noire catches Lin jotting down the time for He Rijun's funeral.

Noire: What's the point? To say a few words in front of a cold stone. It won't bring her back. She won't hear any of our voices again.

Noire: Do you think the soul really exists? What do you think, Teresa? Are you out there, are you listening? Hello, Teresa?!

A long dreadful silence follows, and Noire's lips curl into a sickening smile.

Noire: Heh. What the hell am I doing?

Back in her car now, she fumbles her hand into her glove box, retrieving a painfully empty cigarette case.

The case flies out from the car window. A second passes, and she forces herself out to get it.

Alley

She twists the crinkled gold foil into a strip and slips it into her mouth.

The flimsy taste of tobacco only makes her more restless. She kicks her car door in frustration.

clunk

Noire: Hmm?

A script, from who knows how long ago, slides down from the back seat.

Shadow Spy—it's got the blockbuster appeal her investors wanted, a few innovative concepts to please herself, and even some big names for marquee—still Noire can't shake the feeling that the script isn't good enough.

She and Teresa used to read through new scripts on their own first, then meet to share their interpretations.

The only marks on this script are her own.

Teresa had already left the production before the latest script was printed, and now she was gone.

Noire: He ... Ri ... Jun ...

When they first met, Noire only knew that she was "Teresa," a girl with an elegant if slight figure and an appreciation for stories.

It was only when that graceful girl first spoke of Hong Kong that she realized they had a home in common.

Yet, though she knew she had another name, between them, it had always been Teresa. Just as she had always been Noire.

But "He Rijun" is etched on her tombstone. The name of her friend had died with her.

Noire: Could you help me out one more time, Jun?

Noire is overwhelmed by a sudden impulse, a drive that almost seems to defy all reason.

Noire: Like the old days, when we were in my studio, at my place.

The engine fires up, causing the car to rumble.

Noire: Head to Teresa's grave. Help me find the location. I'm sure Lin's probably marked it in my planner somewhere.

At her command, the puppets spring into motion, searching for the location and then proudly displaying their discovery.

Noire: That's it.

With a shift of gears and a push of the pedal, the engine growls forward.

Her vehicle cuts through the dust, vanishing into the distant darkness of the asphalt road ahead.

Noire: So there I am—too tired and too wired. Every light I saw was green to me, even the red one ... Then, bam.

A gentle gust of wind brushes past, flipping the white paper in the brazier over.

The other side of the white paper is filled with words, losing a battle slowly to the growing fire.

Noire: Well, finally, I'm here, Jun.

Noire: You were always the people-pleaser, bending over backwards to meet everyone's expectations, and then you'd stand in the background with that "don't mind me" smile on your face, making them all forget just how crucial you were.

Noire: You're gone, I get that, but how the hell am I supposed to let you go?

Blackened fragments of paper and gray ash intertwined with a ribbon of red below her.

Noire: Show me what I need to see, just one last time.

The heat lifts the sparks, sending them over the rich green and shimmering orange, until they vanish from view.

Purple

COL-311104

Purple

Office

Noire: ...

On the sofa, a script wriggles like a silkworm struggling inside its cocoon.

Noire: ...

The newspaper reads, "Shadow Spy Sinks! Noire Churns Out Box Office Bomb!"

Noire: *sigh*

It's not the Art Exhibit calling. They don't give invites to failures.

Noire: Lin!

High heels rapidly pounding the concrete draw near, followed by the spilling of papers on the ground.

Lin: What's wrong? Ms. Noire?

Noire: Huh? You're always wearing that purple outfit lately. What happened to the other one you used to wear?

Lin: It just got old. I don't wear it anymore.

Noire: Oh? I always liked that one.

Purple 1984

Noire: Who was that on the phone just now?

Lin: Just the usual, telemarketers, nothing important.

Lin sighs as she ponders how long it's been since she stopped reacting to those calls.

Lin: Here's today's paper, the company documents you never bother with, and this is ...

Lin opens the envelope and quickly scans through its contents.

Lin: Blackmail.

Noire: Really?

Noire's interest piques as she reaches out, gesturing for Lin to help her up from the couch.

Noire: Give it here.

Noire: Hmm ... Ms. Noire, hello. If you don't want this photo to go public, deposit ... one, two, three, four ... only four zeros? ... Into this account by tomorrow.

Noire: The deadline was three days ago?

Noire: Lin ...

Noire flashes Lin a reproachful glance.

Lin: Admin assumed it was just more junk mail and tossed it by the shredder. If Shi hadn't found it, we'd probably never even known.

Lin runs her fingers through her messy hair.

Lin: Well, I guess we'd have found out about it from the papers, eventually.

She deftly extracts the entertainment pages from the stack of newspapers, covering a mess of half-eaten noodles and crumpled papers.

Before long, they locate Noire's photo in a corner of the paper.

Noire: Disgraced Director's Dark Turn: Puppet Abuse Shocker!

Lin: Uh ...

The photo was blurry to begin with, and the cheap print has left the picture all but undecipherable.

Noire: Wow, so not even my scandals are worth anything now?

Noire gestures with her hand, sizing up the space with dissatisfaction.

Noire: My picture's even smaller than Aa Zing's!

Lin: Could this have been someone from the crew?

Noire: No, it's just a shot of me directing Aa Zing and the others during a shoot. How dull. It's nothing, just a story about puppets!

Noire folds her arms behind her head, clearly unimpressed.

Noire: I thought they might've dug up something worth giving a flying. Anyway, I should check through those documents.

Lin: It's a reply from another financier.

Noire: Judging from your expression, this doesn't say how happy they are to be investing in the film.

Lin nods.

Noire: ...

But Noire's expected barb never comes. For Lin, its absence brings a twinge of sadness.

Noire: A couple of flops and that "renowned director" title doesn't quite carry the same weight, does it?

Her eyes wander over the awards on the wall, and she chuckles bitterly.

Noire: No hits means no guarantees. These awards are the only things keeping me fed.

Noire: I'll use this one to sip my soup at lunch, and that pointy one with the spear ... that could make for a decent fork ... might be a bit heavy. Oh, and the square one? A perfect candleholder for the table.

Noire rearranges her awards, setting them on the highest shelf of the bookcase. Save for the ones on the far right-hand side, the others have gathered a layer of dust.

Lin: Ms. Noire, please, let's stop joking around for the moment.

Instead, she gazes with utmost reverence at the row of awards.

Affixed to the leftmost award is a Polaroid photograph. The corner of the photo has faded under the steady stream of sunlight filtering through the curtains.

At the center of the photo, Noire, He Rijun, and Qi Xing beam with wide smiles, their hands cradling an award between them.

At that moment, the cast and crew were grounding in behind them, all smiling. It was the first of C07's hits.

Noire: Those were the glory days. Now, look at Shadow Spy. The box office is in the pits, deep in the pits, still I somehow managed to get three awards for it.

Noire: All the accolades, without the audience ... Heh ...

Her eyes don't drift from the shelf.

Noire: Could you take that photo down for me, Lin?

Lin steps forward and hands the photo to her.

Noire: Now, sell whatever can be sold.

Lin: What?

Noire: Sell off whatever can be sold—the company, the awards, the house, the cars ... Just leave the studio as it is.

Lin: But, where are you going to live?

Noire: It will be a shift going forward. But, at least I'll still have this sofa.

She pats the sofa like an old friend. Lin is still in shock, unable to determine if this is just another one of her jokes.

Lin: And then?

Noire: Put everything we've got into In the Spring Bloom.

Lin: You're serious?

There is a momentary pause as she weighs her decision once more, then a nod.

Noire: Shadow Spy, Plain As Day, The Ice of Smøla—three bombs in a row. No one's going to gamble on me now.

Noire: So it's either this or I leave the industry. I need this one. This is my last chance to prove Noire's still worth a damn.

Noire: If that won't raise enough, then I'll set up meetings, make some social connections, and get the funding together, no matter what it takes.

Lin: ...

Lin can't help but examine her employer. Outwardly, she doesn't seem any different, but it feels as though she has undergone a sudden transformation from within.

Social connections? Selling everything that wasn't nailed down? None of this matches the woman she knows, the one who lived in a frozen world of silver salts and two-dimensional film moving frame by frame.

Now it seems she's entered the world of the living at last.

Lin: Ms. Noire, I've never seen you like this before.

Noire smiles at Lin before steering her wheelchair toward the window.

Noire: I realized how much I relied on her until she was gone. Without Teresa, I've got no chance of holding onto my spot in this savage industry.

Noire: So, if I want to stay afloat, let alone dream of reaching our former heights, I need to start employing a "He Rijun" state of mind.

Noire: This film has to be proof of my transformation. I need to put everything on the line to make it happen.

Noire: Because this may be my last shot.

Her smile was beaming in the reflection of the window, and yet it doesn't seem to hold any warmth.

Lin: You're still studying my reaction, aren't you? Always trying to get a read on me?

Noire: You make it sound so insidious.

Her expression disappears from the glass.

Lin: I'll get it done, Ms. Noire.

Lin: Oh, by the way, there's a letter for you from the hospital.

Lin: The doctor wants you to reconsider going to rehabilitation.

Noire: Leave it on the table.

She glances back, but Lin has already left the office. On top of the stacks of tabloid newspapers lies an aqua-blue letter.

Noire: The hospital ...

Noire: That envelope matches the sky today.

Noire sits in front of the window, waiting without a word for Lin's reply, until the sunset paints the sky a deep orange.

Lin: Ms. Noire.

Noire: Oh? You're back.

There is palpable exhaustion in her voice.

Lin: In the Spring Bloom ... You'll need to arrange your shooting schedule.

Noire: Right.

She stretches and, with a soft motion, taps the aqua-blue envelope.

Noire: The doctor can wait. There's something more urgent I need to take care of.

Aqua

COL-311105

Aqua

Hospital

In the bright, fragrant hallway, a nurse sets a cup of flower tea onto the low table before Noire.

Rehabilitation Nurse: Ms. Noire, you know you're already six months overdue for therapy.

The nurse's words are as soft and sweet as white sugar.

Noire: Sorry, I was shooting a film.

After In the Spring Bloom releases, Lin finally manages to convince Noire to return to the hospital.

Rehabilitation Nurse: Please wait just a moment. The doctor will see you shortly.

Noire: Sure.

The nurse offers a slight bow before heading back to her reception desk.

Even in this private hospital, the waiting area is filled with people. All seats are fully occupied, and at the far end of the hallway, a group of women stands by the wall, engaged in quiet conversation.

Noire looks around briefly before patting the vacant spot on her wheelchair.

Noire: Care to rest your legs for a while?

Lin: ...

As Lin looks at Noire's smiling face, she can't help but sigh.

Lin: Sometimes, I wonder if things were better the way you were before.

Noire: If I hadn't shaped up, then Shi and Alisa would have left the company.

Lin: ...!

Lin: Did they say something to you?

She shakes her head.

Noire: I met an old partner at the launch party. He told me that they had already handed over their resumes to him.

Lin: Uh ...

Noire: But, in the end, they decided to stick around, didn't they?

There seems to be nothing to discern from Noire's smile. All her emotions, good and bad, are locked up somewhere beneath it.

Rehabilitation Nurse: Ms. Noire, the doctor is ready for you. Please, go in.

Noire: Thanks.

She nods to the nurse, who then grips the armrest of the wheelchair and pushes her into the room.

Noire: It won't take long. I'll be out soon.

She turns her head to say the words confidently.

Clinic

Rehabilitation Doctor: Well, judging by the scans, it appears you're recovering well, Ms. Noire.

The doctor uses a magnifying glass to examine the X-rays, pointing at a set of bones that Noire cannot identify.

Rehabilitation Doctor: Based on your condition, with some surgical intervention and rehabilitation, we believe it's possible for you to regain the use of your legs.

Rehabilitation Doctor: However, I see that you've been refusing rehabilitation so far. Is there something specific you are worried about?

Noire: No.

Noire smiles.

Rehabilitation Doctor: Then may I ask why you're refusing treatment?

Noire: Because I needed this.

Ignoring the doctor's confused look, Noire places her hand over her lifeless legs, gently smoothing out the wrinkles in her skirt.

Noire: These useless legs and this chair. They remind me that I never want to return to the way I was before.

Handel's Harp Concerto in B-flat Major weaves through the air from a distant radio, with only the harp's rich, soothing tones drawing the ear.

Noire: That's it.

Noire shuts her eyes, taking in a deep, steady breath.

Noire: Aqua.

Aqua 1985

Noire's Set

On the set of In the Spring Bloom.

Noire: Cut!

As Noire's voice rings out, the leading couple in the spotlight pull away from their tight embrace with professional distance, the set around them coming to life with movement and chatter.

Water is handed out, and makeup is retouched. Crew members flit past the camera's frame, attending to their duties.

In the corner tent, Noire and her assistant director stand by the monitor, speaking in low tones. A quick nod from Noire brings the script supervisor, megaphone in hand, toward the center of the set.

Alisa: That's a wrap, everyone!

Crowd: Yeah!!!

A wave of energy follows the announcement, but for a few present, the rush of completion is replaced with the impending task of finishing their work.

At the far end of the set, two crew members rush forward, holding bright bouquets. They give them to the lead actors, then beg to take a photo to mark the end of filming.

The props team is bringing a bamboo ladder out to clear away the decorations. One by one, they begin to check and count the inventory, making sure nothing is left behind.

Alisa heads back to the director's tent.

Alisa: Tonight, Ms. Noire has organized up a wrap party at Ching Wo Lau! It's been a tough shoot, so we're all expected to eat, drink, and let loose. Let's have a great time!

Crowd: Thank you, Ms. Noire!

The news of the wrap party in the evening lifts spirits all around.

As the crew moves about, tidying up the set with relaxed efficiency, Noire turns to Lin, observing her quietly.

Noire: So, what do you think?

Lin: It's a great New Year comedy, one that oozes your unique style, but with a lot of commercial appeal.

Noire: No, not the movie. I want to know about the atmosphere on the set. What's your take?

The crew is busy tearing down the set as the studio begins to take on its original appearance once more.

Noire: This was the set for Shadow Spy, once upon a time.

Lin: It's a far cry from those days. The set is so full of life now.

Lin: Your transformation has had an impact on everyone.

Noire lowers her head and smooths out the creases in her skirt.

Noire: Really? Not bad ... not bad at all.

With a tender touch, Noire's fingers glide over the fabric of her skirt. It's hard to tell just what she's most pleased by.

Lin: Right ...

Lin: Right ...

Before long, Noire emerges from the examination room, a smile on her face as she shares the details of what occurred inside.

Once more, that same inscrutable feeling envelops Lin.

Lin: So, you're going to give up your legs ... as some kind of reminder?

Noire: It's more than that. They're a balance, or an anchor, if you will. A reminder not to lose myself in my own world again—not to neglect the people around me.

Noire's fingers run over the fabric of her skirt, and Lin, now sure of it, realizes her earlier suspicion was right.

Noire: They remind me how much I rely on all of you and the price I paid when I lost her.

All along, Noire has been silently thanking her legs.

Noire: That's why I refused treatment.

And I intend to stay like this forever.

Noire: I've told you before that I wouldn't let them interfere with my work. They haven't.

Lin: ...

Noire: But you, Lin. You followed me this whole way. You even sold your clothes. Why didn't you ever consider leaving?

Lin: You figured that out, did you?

Noire: That outfit wasn't nearly old enough for you to just get rid of it for no reason.

She recalls that day and her old purple suit. The day she told her a lie.

Lin: It's ...

Lin: It's just that I wanted to see what you could do. Whether you could really make it work.

Noire: So, did you find out the answer?

Lin: ...

She gently pats Lin, then pushes the wheelchair toward the hospital exit by herself.

The golden rays glinting off the wheel are almost blinding.

The high heels and clacking wooden puppet steps fade away beyond an automatic door.

Noire: I'm going to need you to take care of these doctors again. They've decided I need more psychological counseling.

Lin: Oh, okay.

There is some quiet satisfaction she takes in how her once tyrannical boss has become so dependent on her.

Yellow

COL-311106

Yellow

Award Ceremony

Award Presenter: And now, the films nominated for Best Director this year are—

Award Presenter: Wang Changmai—A Century Away from Home, Xu Liuqing—The Codebreaker, and Noire—Where Shadows Walk.

Award Presenter: And the winner of the Best Director Award is—

Award Presenter: Noire—Where Shadows Walk! Congratulations!

Gold 1988

Office

The day before the award ceremony.

Noire: Boring, dull, trite, inane.

Several scripts land on the floor. Noire taps the wheel impatiently.

Noire: Why are all these films just rehashes of everything I've watched since the day I was born? Haven't we had enough of these already?

Lin: These are all the scripts Alisa screened. There isn't a single one you're happy with?

Noire: Switching around a few jobs and characters doesn't make a new story. Some of these arcs are totally incoherent. They've just been thrown in to match this year's box office template.

Noire: I'm tired of reading them. Just imagine how much worse it will be for those poor audiences.

Noire: There should be a waiting period—thirty years at least—before filmmakers are allowed to use the same old tricks. Let us grow old in peace and try them again on the new generation.

Noire waves her hand dismissively, prompting Lin to gather the scripts from the table and throw them into a waiting trash can.

Noire: Any response from the writers?

The company's screenwriting team. When Noire's films returned to the public eye, she was buried in opportunities from all directions.

Old film companies with proud legacies, new conglomerates yet to enter the movie industry but eager to claim their share, and even a few unsavory underground organizations.

Lin: No.

Lin: However, I hear they're working on a crime flick.

Noire: Another crime drama. The police certainly have their hands full, don't they?

Lin: You have eight meetings today, and three of them overlap. Somehow, you'll need to squeeze in time for another script.

Lin: And your first meeting started about seventeen minutes ago.

Noire is about to speak, but Lin beats her to the punch.

Lin: As the head of the film department, it's your duty to assess all new movie plans.

Lin: And now you've got a boss of your own.

Noire: ...

Noire's half-parted lips move as if to speak, but then she reconsiders.

Noire: It beats having to deal with telemarketers.

With a casual wave, Noire maneuvers her wheelchair and exits the office.

Noire: *sigh*

In the quiet of the night, following a full day of meetings, Noire finds herself alone on the company rooftop.

Across the city, neon lights pulse in steady patterns, and headlights streak through the streets. A lively performance but one devoid of joy.

There's no sound but the soft rippling of wind.

Noire: ...

Staring out into the faint specks of light in the far distance of the night, Noire takes a cigarette from her pocket. As she moves to light it, a woman's voice startles her.

Lin: Ms. Noire.

Noire: Ah!

Her hand trembles, and the cigarette slips from between her fingers, plummeting from the rooftop into the shadows below.

Noire: That was ... my last one ... Lin.

Noire turns her head, revealing a painfully phony smile.

Noire: Why aren't you home already?

Lin: I've been going through the minutes.

Noire: It's late. Go home. I need a little space to focus on myself for a change, alright?

Lin: What are you thinking about?

Noire: What else? The film, of course.

Lin: You're still thinking about it?

Noire doesn't respond all at once, choosing instead to look back over the cityscape in silence.

Noire: This is a thriving international city—glitz, glamour, and excess—but from here, it feels like I can hold it all in the palm of my hand.

Noire: This city is filled with countless dreamers, young souls pushing through harsh realities, hoping for one moment when destiny finally smiles on them.

Noire: And when those chosen few finally get the chance to rise to the top, they understand—there's not much up here after all.

Noire: And in that instant, how does that dreamer feel?

The skyscrapers at the limits of her gaze are nothing but darkened silhouettes, with green lasers tracing patterns far beyond them in the night sky.

Lin: I'd guess it's close to how you feel right now.

Noire: It isn't enough.

In the end, the inferno will devour all that surrounds them.

Lin observes Noire at her side, her expression now solemn as she fixes her gaze far beyond the skyline.

Noire: I'm done with this city. My art belongs across the Pacific, beyond these waves, not stuck between these little islands.

Noire: Are you curious to see whether I'll succeed, or do you just want to be there when I crash and burn?

Lin: Either one.

Lin snaps with a feigned indifference.

Lin: Because I can feel myself becoming the same kind of person.

Noire: Thank you, thank you!

Noire wheels herself onto the stage, her voice muffled at first as the microphone hasn't yet been lowered to her level.

Noire: My thanks go out to the judges and the crew. This isn't just my award—this award belongs to all of us. Where Shadows Walk is the culmination of so many people's combined effort and dedication.

As she says this, Noire tilts herself toward the crew's seating area, bowing courteously. The crowd erupts in applause once more.

Noire: It's strange being back up here.

Noire: So much has changed since the first time I stood on this stage.

Noire taps the frame of her wheelchair, eliciting a round of good-natured laughter from the audience.

Noire: It's tough, loyal, and always there when I need it. If only we could say the same about everyone in our lives.

Noire intentionally holds the silence, watching the faint flickers of awkward smiles forming in the crowd.

Noire: The loss of a close friend, the crash, the paralysis ... I won't lie, these past years have been hard, and I've been silent for much of it.

Noire: A lot of people had their doubts about me. Some decided to abandon me entirely. And I don't entirely blame them.

Noire: I've always thought of life as a montage of moments, and with so much behind me now, my picture's completely changed.

Noire: Just being able to be up here again is proof enough to the world that I'm still going strong!

Noire gazes over the sea of faces beneath her. There are a few she knows, but far more she's never met.

Her mind lingers on those missing from the crowd—the ones who left the craft behind, the ones who didn't have a choice.

She pauses, her head bowed in silent reflection, but as she lifts her gaze, her director's persona resurfaces.

Noire: To everyone who supported us, I offer you my heartfelt thanks. On this momentous day, I have something important to share with you all.

Noire: I've decided it's time to bid farewell to the past and embark on a new adventure. I hope you'll all be looking forward to it.

Her eyes sweep over the crowd, their shared tongue and similar upbringing reminding her of the connections they still hold.

Noire: Until next year, everyone.

Amid the audience's cheers, Noire makes her way down from the stage.

Within half an hour, she and Lin are already on a flight to Los Angeles.

Noire: Take one final look.

Noire lifts the shade covering the airplane window.

Noire: It's only a matter of hours now, then we'll be stepping into the great unknown. Are you ready for it, Lin?

Lin: Good night.

Following Lin's words, Noire lets her eye mask slip down, settling down comfortably into her chair.

Noire: Good night.

The runway blurs beneath the plane as it speeds up, and after a fleeting moment of weightlessness, the pale dots of red and green below blur and vanish into the night.

Noire: Goodbye, goodnight.

White

COL-311107

White

Young Noire: Mommy, watch me! I can ride a horse now!

Mother:

Hmm, how wonderful.

Young Noire: Mommy loves me a lot. I know she does.

Young Noire: Look, Mommy, I drew this.

Mother:

That's lovely, my sweet girl.

Young Noire: She was always so gentle and patient with me. Her words were a constant stream of encouragement and support.

Young Noire: Mommy, can you listen to the new song I learned on the piano?

Mother:

You go ahead and play it, darling. Mommy still needs to finish chatting with your uncles and aunties. I'll be sitting in the living room listening.

Young Noire: Still, deep down, I always felt ... she never tried to form a deeper connection with the person I truly was. All she wanted was for me to be a "good girl."

Young Noire: Until ...

Young Noire: Mommy, I heard the aunties chatting in the kitchen this morning.

Mother:

Yes?

Young Noire: They said ...

Young Noire: Her eyes were fixed on me, as if silently urging me to keep talking.

Young Noire: Then it hit me—I'd found the perfect hook to keep Mommy's eyes on me forever.

Young Noire: I need to hold on to this moment, and show her a part of myself she's never seen before.

Young Noire: Auntie said that ... she lost her purse on her way to buy groceries this morning.

Mother:

Oh? And then?

Young Noire: Auntie searched all along the way she'd walked, but in the end, she had to go to the police.

Mother:

Hmm ...

Young Noire: It feels like Mommy's not fully focused anymore. Maybe it's because she already knew how the story would end.

Young Noire: But then ...!

Young Noire: I spoke louder to hold her attention. I had to think up something to change the course of the story.

Young Noire: She saw that her pocket was torn, and her wallet slipped into the lining of her pants.

Mother:

So the wallet wasn't lost after all?

Young Noire: But ... actually ... it was all just a dream I had last night.

Young Noire: I made it all up. I made up a lie to get her attention and then made up another one to keep it.

Mother:

Oh, next time, you should tell me that part of the story first.

Young Noire: But if I had told you that first, how would I have managed to hold your attention?

Noire: As she walked away, it was like she was stepping into a heavy fog formed by her other responsibilities. Where she wasn't only a mother—she was a businesswoman, a leader, a manager ...

Noire: It was an expanse of white created by combining every color in the world.

Young Noire: It's the best color to complement all the others.

Young Noire: Without the white, we wouldn't be able to see the red clearly.

Young Noire: Shh ... She hasn't even figured it out herself yet.

White 1991

Film Studio

Noire: Oh, the phone's ringing.

Bright incandescent bulbs fill the room with a solid white light. Her new studio is practically identical to the one she sold back home.

Her first film.

An old group photo.

And the wheelchair she made the choice to depend on.

Noire: It's a snapshot of my life, but it's still not enough to recreate an authentic version of me.

Noire's fingers dance through her short hair, her head gracefully tilting to the right.

Noire: A green light ... Is this green metaphor really enough?

She absorbs herself in thought.

Noire: Or perhaps we need to alter the order of colors as they emerge from the darkness?

She mumbles.

Noire: Standing in front of that grave, Qi Xing would be so angry with me ...

Noire nonchalantly waves her puppets away. They retreat back into her wheelchair.

Noire: Maybe it's because I can only think of Teresa in situations like this?

Lost in her thoughts, the wheelchair slowly rolls her back to the computer.

Noire: What do you think that was? A memory, or a story?

Noire: Do you think that's true? Really?

Noire powers up the computer, and a blue glow washes over her face.

Noire: Try as we might to disguise it. Stories are just lies with good marketing.

Noire: And you are the observer to this little tale, so you alone have the power to judge.